

Purity, Piety, and Property

600-1485

Modern impressions of medieval women, especially in Western societies, highlight their chastity, obedience, and their lack of autonomy. Limitations were placed on women by religion, custom, and law, and many women's lives were dominated by their duties as wives, mothers, and workers, with any earnings for their labors often going to their husbands. Yet women did not always fulfill the image of pure, meek, and subservient wives and daughters that has been painted. In some medieval societies, women had a surprising amount of freedom, and the historical record is littered with stories of strong female warriors, religious leaders, and property owners.